Through a Parkdale Lens: Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Services in Toronto: Methodology

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Research Methodology

The central research question asks how newcomer families describe their experiences of accessing and using, or not using, the family support services offered or referred through one Toronto child care centre. It is a question about how a process unfolds, not about how often an outcome occurs, and this distinction is what leads the study to a qualitative methodology. Qualitative research explores a central phenomenon through the detailed accounts of a small number of participants, allowing the researcher to learn from those participants instead of testing variables chosen beforehand (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). A tally of fee subsidy applications at the centre would show which families applied, but it could not show what a parent believed the eligibility rules to be, who explained the application, or at which step the family decided to stop. These are the details on which the research question depends, and they become available only when parents are given room to reconstruct the sequence in their own words. Depth, in this sense, is less a preference than a requirement of the question itself.

Qualitative inquiry also treats the setting of an experience as part of the evidence (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). For the families in this study, the relevant setting is institutional as much as physical. It includes the form in which the centre circulated information, whether that information was available in a language the parent reads comfortably, which referrals staff made and when, and what a particular application asked a family to produce. Two parents at the same centre can meet these conditions very differently, for instance when one works evening shifts and rarely sees the notice board, or when one has the tax-filing history that a subsidy application assumes and the other does not. Since most of this context reaches the researcher through what parents recount, an interview held on Zoom or by phone can still document it, although such formats offer fewer non-verbal cues and no view of the family's surroundings. I will offset part of this loss by asking parents to walk through concrete episodes, such as the day they first read

about a program or sat down to complete a form, so that contextual detail is anchored in specific events and not left to general impressions.

A further reason concerns meaning. Qualitative research is grounded in an interest in how people make meaning of their social realities, which allows participants' interpretations to stand alongside, and at times against, institutional ones (Mwita, 2022). Family support services are usually designed, named, and explained from the provider's side. A term such as eligibility, or the difference between a centre's own waitlist and the City's subsidy waitlist, may be self-evident to an educator and remain unclear to a parent who is still learning how Toronto's child care system is organized. Were the study to decide in advance what counts as a barrier or as help, it would risk documenting the researcher's categories while missing the families' own. Open-ended questions leave the definition of those categories to parents, which is what a study of access from the family's position requires.

Research Design

Within this methodology, the study will use a qualitative descriptive design. Sandelowski (2000) characterizes qualitative description as a comprehensive summary of events in the everyday terms of those events, produced by a researcher who stays close to the data and to the surface of participants' words. The design does not exclude interpretation. Sandelowski (2010) later clarified that all description involves interpretive choices, but that in this design those choices remain close to what participants report instead of moving toward abstract theoretical claims. The analytic approach follows the same logic. Interviews will be analyzed through thematic analysis at the semantic level, where codes capture the explicit content of what participants say (Braun & Clarke, 2022), so that the analysis does not reach further than the design allows.

The stronger argument for this design concerns execution, that is, how it makes the study possible to carry out in a way that answers the research question. Because qualitative description reports events in participants' own terms (Sandelowski, 2000), the interview protocol can be organized around the sequence a family actually moves through, from hearing about a service

and working out what it requires to looking for help and deciding whether to use it. The same sequence can then structure the findings. Each stage of the analysis will correspond to part of the first sub-question, on what helped or limited families, while the final stage addresses the second, on how the centre responded to families' needs. The design also suits the conditions of a student project. It is commonly used when information must come directly from the people affected and when time and resources are limited (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024), and it typically relies on a single round of semi-structured interviews (Bradshaw et al., 2017). With four interviews scheduled for Weeks 2 to 4 and a findings report due in Week 7, a design that does not require repeated rounds of data collection is what keeps the schedule realistic. Because its findings remain close to participants' words, they can also be read and used by practitioners (Villamin et al., 2025). Here, they would show the centre's educators which explanations and referrals parents found useful and where communication between the centre and families broke down.

Participants, Recruitment and Sampling Plan

Participants and Recruitment

Participants

Four newcomer parents or primary caregivers will take part. Following Massing et al. (2024), a newcomer family is defined here as an immigrant or refugee family with young children that has lived in Canada for five years or less. To be eligible, a parent must (a) be 18 or older, (b) have arrived in Canada within the past five years, (c) have a child enrolled at the study centre, (d) have received information about, or a referral to, at least one family support service from the centre in the past 12 months, such as the City of Toronto child care fee subsidy, EarlyON programs, or settlement services, and (e) be able to participate in English or Mandarin, or with an interpreter.

Each criterion is tied to what the research question requires a participant to be able to describe. The five-year limit keeps the focus on families who are still learning how services are organized, while criteria (c) and (d) ensure that every participant has encountered the centre's information or referrals recently enough to recall them in detail. Criterion (d) is deliberately

neutral about outcomes. Parents who decided not to apply, or who began an application and stopped, are as relevant to the question as parents who used a service, because non-use is itself one of the experiences the study sets out to understand. These differences will be described within each family's account. They will not be used to form comparison groups, since a sample of four cannot support claims about differences between users and non-users.

Three exclusions follow from ethical and conceptual considerations. Families with whom I worked directly during my field placement will not be invited, because a parent who knows me as their child's educator may find it difficult to decline or to speak critically about the centre (Villamin et al., 2025). Centre staff and their family members will also be excluded, as their employment could create pressure to participate or to present the centre favourably. The third exclusion, parents who already hold Canadian citizenship, is conceptual. The first sub-question asks what helps or limits families in meeting service requirements, and for newcomers those requirements are often shaped by immigration status, as with the tax-filing history on which fee subsidy eligibility depends (Toronto Children's Services, 2025). A parent who has become a citizen applies under the same conditions as a parent born in Canada, so their account would say little about how status-related requirements affect access. Because citizenship normally follows several years of residence, the exclusion is also expected to affect very few parents within the five-year period. Permanent residents, refugees and refugee claimants, and parents holding work or study permits will all be eligible, since each status carries distinct eligibility conditions that form part of what families experience.

Screening will be limited to two questions, namely when the parent arrived in Canada and whether they hold Canadian citizenship. Immigration category will not be asked about. Fee subsidy applications require tax documents that undocumented families often cannot provide (Schmidt, 2026), and wider questions about status could signal risk to such families and discourage them from responding.

Recruitment Setting

Recruitment will take place at a licensed child care centre in the Parkdale neighbourhood of west Toronto, where I completed my field placement. The centre will not be named in this proposal or in any report, so that families cannot be identified through the setting. The site is suitable for both substantive and practical reasons. Substantively, the centre already circulates information about family support services and refers families to them, which means its parents have the experiences the research question asks about. Toronto's service plan also identifies child care settings as access points to family services and names tax-filing requirements as a barrier to fee subsidy (Toronto Children's Services, 2025), so a single centre offers a meaningful vantage point on how city services reach newcomer families. Practically, my placement gives me access to the centre and familiarity with its routines, which makes recruitment within the course timeline feasible. The same familiarity, however, is the reason families I worked with directly are excluded.

Recruitment Methods

Recruitment will begin only after approval from the George Brown Polytechnic Research Ethics Board (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022) and written permission from the centre director. No families will be contacted until both are in place. I will then create a plain-language, one-page flyer and a letter of information and translate them into Mandarin and other languages often used at the centre. The materials will describe the purpose of the study, the total time of about 60 to 75 minutes for one meeting, the voluntary nature of participation, the $25 gift card, and my contact information, so that parents can make an informed decision.

The $25 gift card acknowledges the 60 to 75 minutes that the meeting asks of each parent. However, any incentive may raise concerns about pressure to participate. The Tri-Council Policy Statement asks researchers to consider participants' economic circumstances so that incentives do not become undue inducements (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022). Head (2009) also discusses how payment in qualitative research can acknowledge participants' time while raising concerns about undue influence on consent, and Flicker et al.

(2007) treat fair compensation as an ethical question that review boards should weigh against the risk of coercion. A modest $25 card is unlikely to pressure families into joining, especially because it is not tied to completing the interview. Parents will receive it at the beginning of the meeting and keep it even if they withdraw, and the Research Ethics Board will review the amount.

The director will share the invitation through the parent newsletter, the notice board, and families' cubbies, and staff will not approach families individually. As in Hardware et al. (2026), a person other than the lead researcher will distribute the invitation, which separates the request to participate from my earlier role at the centre. Because a notice from the director may still be seen as a request from the centre, the flyer will explain that the centre will not know which parents participate and that participation will not affect any child's care. If fewer than four parents respond by the middle of Week 1, the director will send one reminder.

Sampling Plan

Sampling Strategy. I will use purposive sampling, in which the researcher intentionally selects people who can help to understand the central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). What makes the sample purposive here is experience. Participants are newcomer parents who arrived in Canada within the past five years and who have received information about, or a referral to, a family support service from the centre. Within this group, the sample will be one of convenience, drawn from parents who are available and willing to take part at a site I can already access. Convenience sampling is efficient for small studies but limits how far findings can be extended beyond the people who chose to respond (Stratton, 2021), a limitation that is consistent with the descriptive and non-generalizing aims of this study. The purposive criteria therefore decide who is eligible, and convenience decides where and how eligible parents are reached.

Participant Selection. Parents who are interested will contact me directly by email, phone, or text, and a 10-minute call will confirm whether they meet the inclusion and exclusion criteria. Screening and selection will take place outside the centre, which will not learn who responded. Eligible parents will then receive the letter of information and consent form in their

preferred language and will have at least 48 hours to decide. The first four eligible parents who agree to participate will form the sample, with no more than one adult per family. Others will be offered a place on a waitlist and contacted in order if a participant withdraws before the interview. Selection by order of contact is a pragmatic choice for a sample of four, though it may favour parents with the time and confidence to respond quickly, and the findings will be read with that limitation in mind.

Sample Size. The study will include four participants. This is the number set for individual projects in the course, and it falls within the range of about four to eight participants commonly used in qualitative studies so that each person's experience can be explored in detail (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). The size of the sample also shapes what the study can claim. The findings will describe these four families' experiences closely, will not be presented as representative of newcomer families in Toronto, and will not claim to have reached data saturation.

Data Collection

Procedure

Data will be collected through individual, semi-structured, in-depth interviews. The interview is the method, and the interview protocol is the tool through which it is carried out. The protocol will be developed with the phased framework proposed by Kallio et al. (2016), which moves from identifying what the interview must cover to drafting, piloting, and finalizing the guide. Its open-ended questions and follow-up probes will give each conversation a consistent structure while leaving room to pursue details that a parent raises unexpectedly. Individual interviews are preferable to focus groups for this study, since income and subsidy eligibility are sensitive topics and parents from one centre may know one another (Villamin et al., 2025). Before Week 1, the protocol will be piloted with one newcomer parent from outside the study to test its wording, translation, and length.

Each participant will take part in one meeting of about 60 to 75 minutes, scheduled at a time that suits the family. Families may choose a private room at the centre outside drop-off and

pick-up times, Zoom, or a phone call, and parents who join online may turn off their camera and use a pseudonym, as in Hardware et al. (2026). I will interview Mandarin-speaking parents myself. For other languages, a trained interpreter who has signed a confidentiality agreement will take part, so that meaning is not lost in translation (Ilumin, 2023). The meeting will proceed in three steps:

1. **Consent (about 10 minutes).** I will review the letter of information with the parent in their preferred language and respond to any questions before consent is given. The parent will then sign the consent form or give recorded verbal consent and will receive the $25 gift card.
2. **Background form (about 5 minutes).** The parent will note years in Canada, children's ages, home language, and the services the centre shared or referred. The form will not ask about immigration category or income.
3. **Interview (45 to 60 minutes).** With the parent's permission, the interview will be audio-recorded. The questions will follow the steps a family takes toward a service. Parents will first be invited to describe how they learned about a service, what they understood about its eligibility rules and application process, and who helped them along the way, whether an educator, a settlement worker, or a relative. The conversation will then turn to what led the family to use or not use the service. In the final part, parents will be asked whether they were able to raise needs related to their language and culture, how educators responded, and what they would want the centre to do differently. At the end, each parent will receive a list of community supports, such as EarlyON and 211 Toronto.

Participation is voluntary at every stage. Parents may decline any question or end the interview at any point, and they will keep the gift card if they do. They may also withdraw their data within one week of the interview, before coding of that interview begins, with no effect on their child's care. Recordings and transcripts will carry pseudonyms and will be stored in encrypted, password-protected files kept apart from the consent forms. Only I will keep the list

that links pseudonyms to names. Because a small sample from one centre can make people identifiable, my reports will not combine details such as country of origin and home language, and any quotation that could identify a family will be changed or left out (Villamin et al., 2025).

Timeline of Research Study

Table 1

Timeline of the Research Study

Period	Research activity	Main tasks
By December 2026	Ethics and preparation	Ethics approval, the director's permission, translation of materials, and a pilot of the interview protocol
Weeks 1 and 2	Recruit participants	Invitation circulated by the director, a reminder in mid-Week 1 if needed, screening calls, consent, and interviews booked
Weeks 2 and 3	Collect data	First interviews held in Week 2, at least three of four (75%) completed by the end of Week 3, each transcribed within days
Week 4	Complete data collection	Fourth interview held and initial semantic coding started
Week 5	Preliminary findings	Summary of preliminary findings submitted
Weeks 6 and 7	Complete analysis	Themes finalized from the semantic codes and the findings report submitted in Week 7
Weeks 8 and 9	Refine findings	Findings revised in light of instructor feedback
Week 10	Presentation draft	Presentation drafted
Weeks 11 to 13	Revise	Presentation rehearsed and the final report revised and proofread
Week 14	Final submission	Final report submitted

The schedule rests on one condition that lies outside my control, which is that ethics approval must be granted before the term begins, because recruitment opens in Week 1 and interviews begin in Week 2. If approval is delayed, every later stage will move back by the same interval while keeping its order. Transcribing each interview within days of conducting it allows coding to start in Week 4, and this is what makes a summary of preliminary findings possible by Week 5. Decisions, changes, and unexpected difficulties will be recorded in a reflexive journal

throughout the study, so that any departure from this plan can be accounted for in the final report.

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